

The Interaction Round and Group Discussion

The stage that comes before the technical round - and can end the day

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Study pack - part 9 of 10

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Why this document is high priority

Tomorrow's order is: **pre-placement talk** → **interaction round (possibly a GD)** → **technical round** → **HR round**.

Read that carefully. **The GD comes before the technical round.** If it is an elimination stage - and in campus processes it usually is - then everything you know about OSPF, subnetting and WebSockets is worth nothing until you get past a twenty-minute conversation with eight other students.

This is also, quietly, the round most aligned with the job. The JD lists “**good communication skills, be an active listener**” twice - the only requirement it repeats - and adds “ability to co-ordinate and interact with various teams” and “ability to interact effectively at all levels with sensitivity to cultural diversity”. A GD is BT literally watching for those things.

Good news: unlike networking, this round is not about knowledge. It is about behaviour, and behaviour can be decided in advance. Read this once, decide how you will behave, and you are prepared.

Part A - The pre-placement talk

Most candidates treat this as the boring part before the real thing. It is not.

What to do:

- **Sit near the front and take written notes.** Visible attention is noticed, and the notes are genuinely useful.
- **Write down whatever they emphasise.** If they spend time on the full-fibre rollout, on AI in the network, on their values, on shift patterns, on the training programme - that is what the people interviewing you later care about. Repeating their own emphasis back at them later in the day is free credibility.
- **Write down names and roles** of whoever presents. “You mentioned in the talk that...” is a strong opening to a question.
- **Note anything that contradicts or updates document 05.** Their live numbers beat my research. If they say something different about the Kolkata office or the business, use theirs.
- **Ask a question if there is a Q&A** - one, short, and about the work. Not about salary. Your questions from document 05 all work here.

What not to do: phone out, slouching, whispering, or leaving early. In campus processes, HR often sits at the back precisely to watch this.

Part B - The interaction round

An “interaction round” can mean two things, and you will know within the first minute which it is:

1. **A group discussion** - a topic given to a group of 8-12, ten to twenty minutes, panel observing. Covered in Part C.
2. **A conversational round** - a panel member talks with you or a small group, informally. No topic, no debate. They are checking that you are articulate, pleasant and not scripted.

If it is the conversational kind, the whole game is: be a normal, warm, clear person. Answer in full sentences, show some personality, ask something back if it fits the flow. Do not deliver rehearsed paragraphs - this round is designed to catch memorised answers. If they ask “so tell me about yourself”, give the human version from document 00, not the technical one.

One thing that works in both formats: when someone else is speaking, actually look at them and listen. Panels watch for this. Most candidates spend other people’s speaking time visibly rehearsing their own next line, and it is obvious.

Part C - The group discussion

How you are actually scored

Panels are not marking who was loudest or who talked longest. They score roughly:

What they watch	What good looks like
Content	Did you say something with substance, or just noise?
Communication	Clear, structured, unhurried English
Listening	Did you build on others, or ignore them?
Group behaviour	Did you help the discussion, or fight it?
Leadership	Did you open, summarise, or bring someone in?
Composure	Did you stay calm when interrupted or contradicted?

Three or four good contributions beat ten interruptions. Quality is scored, volume is not.

The eight rules

- 1. Speak in the first two minutes.** The longer you wait the harder it gets, and a candidate who never speaks cannot be scored at all - which is an automatic fail. If you cannot open, get in second or third.
- 2. Opening is high risk, high reward.** If you open, do it properly: define the topic, set out the two or three angles the group could take, then hand over. *"I think there are three sides to this - the technology, the cost, and the impact on people. Let me start with the technology."* If you cannot do that cleanly, let someone else open and come in second with structure.
- 3. Structure every contribution.** Point → reason → example → hand back. Twenty to forty seconds. Do not ramble; do not deliver a speech.
- 4. Build on others by name.** *"Building on what Ankit said about cost -"* This is the single highest-scoring habit in a GD, because it proves you were listening, which is precisely what BT says it wants. Use it at least twice.
- 5. Never interrupt. Never raise your voice.** If two people are already talking over each other, wait. When it clears, say *"Can I add something here?"* - the panel will have noticed who stayed calm.
- 6. If you are cut off, do not fight.** Let them finish, then: *"Just to finish my earlier point -"* Composure under interruption is explicitly being tested, and in an operations role it maps directly to handling a frustrated customer.
- 7. Bring in a quiet person once.** *"Priya, you were about to say something?"* It costs you five seconds and it marks you as someone who makes a team work. Panels remember it.
- 8. Summarise near the end if nobody has.** *"So broadly we agreed on X, there was some disagreement about Y, and the common ground seems to be Z."* A clean summary is often the single best-scored contribution in the entire discussion. **If you have been quiet so far, this is your rescue move.**

What loses the round

- Not speaking at all - guaranteed elimination.
- Dominating, interrupting, talking over people.
- Getting personal or aggressive when someone disagrees.
- Repeating a point already made, with no addition.
- Fabricating statistics. **Say “I read that roughly...” rather than inventing a precise number.** If someone challenges an invented figure you cannot defend, the damage is worse than not having said it.
- Sitting rigidly silent while looking at the table.

If you genuinely know nothing about the topic

It happens. Two safe routes, both of which score:

- **Ask a framing question and then structure it.** *“I’d like to understand the scope - are we discussing this for India specifically, or globally? Because the answer is quite different.”*
- **Speak from the human side.** Almost every GD topic has a people angle - who is affected, who benefits, what is fair - and you can reason about that without any data.

Never bluff facts. **Never** sit silent.

Part D - Likely GD topics, with the angles

BT is a telecom company hiring for a service and operations role, so topics skew toward technology, telecom and workplace themes. For each, here is a *position and two angles* - enough to say something structured within thirty seconds.

Technology and telecom

“Will AI replace jobs?” - Very likely, and it is a live topic at BT specifically, since their CEO has said AI may reduce headcount further. *Angle:* AI removes tasks faster than it removes jobs; the roles that change are the repetitive ones, and roles requiring judgement, escalation and human contact are more resilient. Balanced landing: *“It shifts what people do rather than removing the need for people - but only if people are retrained, which is the part that gets neglected.”*

“5G / digital connectivity in India” - *Angle:* the gap between coverage and meaningful access - affordability and digital literacy matter as much as towers. Rural connectivity is where the real impact is.

“Is technology making us less social?” - *Angle:* it changes the shape of connection rather than reducing it; the honest problem is attention and quality, not quantity.

“Data privacy vs convenience” - *Angle:* people trade privacy for convenience because the cost is invisible and delayed. Regulation exists because individuals cannot realistically evaluate that trade.

“Work from home vs work from office” - *Angle:* depends on the job. A 24/7 operations function needs handovers and shared context; individual deep work does not. Hybrid is the sensible answer, and say *why*, not just *what*.

“Should social media be regulated?” - *Angle:* the difficulty is drawing the line between harm prevention and censorship, and who gets to draw it.

General and abstract

“Does India need more engineers or more entrepreneurs?” - *Angle:* a false choice - the constraint is quality of training and access to capital, not the count of either.

“Money vs job satisfaction”, “Success or happiness”, “Is failure the best teacher?” - abstract topics. *Approach:* refuse the false binary early and reframe. *“I don’t think these are opposites - the real question is what you optimise for when you have to choose, and at what stage of your life.”* That single move usually lifts the whole discussion and gets noticed.

The BT-specific bonus

If a topic touches telecom, technology, or infrastructure at all, you have material from document 05 that nobody else in the room has: **the UK full-fibre rollout past two-thirds of homes, replacing copper**. Use it as an example - *“To take one example, BT is replacing its entire copper network with fibre, which is a decade-long investment before the returns show up”* - and you have quietly demonstrated that you researched the company, inside a GD, without being asked to.

Use it once. Not three times.

Part E - Speaking well tomorrow

The vocabulary test is behind you. What matters now is spoken clarity, in the GD and three conversations.

- **Slow down.** Nervousness speeds you up. Slightly slower than feels natural is almost always better.
 - **One idea per sentence.** Long sentences are where clarity dies.
 - **Cut the fillers** - “basically”, “actually”, “like”, “you know”, “as such”, “means”. Silence between sentences is better than filler.
 - **Finish your sentences.** Trailing off makes a correct answer sound uncertain.
 - **Pausing is allowed.** “*Let me think about that for a second*” sounds far better than noise.
 - **Ask when unclear.** “*Sorry, could you repeat that?*” or “*Do you mean X or Y?*” In a role that lists active listening as a requirement, this is a positive signal, not a weakness.
 - **Sit up, hands still, look at whoever is speaking.** In a GD, look around the group - not only at the panel.
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The one-page reminder for tomorrow

Pre-placement talk: notes out, sit forward, write down what they emphasise, one good question if there is a Q&A.

Interaction / GD: 1. Speak within the first two minutes. 2. Point → reason → example → hand back. Thirty seconds. 3. Build on someone by name, at least twice. 4. Never interrupt, never raise your voice, never get personal. 5. Bring a quiet person in once. 6. Summarise at the end if nobody has. 7. No invented statistics. 8. Look at whoever is speaking.

Technical round: documents 01, 02 and 03. Lead them to ChatterBox. Short answers, then stop. “I don’t know” is allowed - bluffing is not.

HR round: document 07. Humble, honest, specific. No ownership language.

All day: you have already cleared the OA. Everyone in that room did too. What separates people now is who is calm, clear and easy to work with - which is entirely within your control.